

The Baton and the Race

A Lineage-Primary Analogy for Digital Preservation

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Purpose: This document provides an analogy to help archivists, technologists, and policy designers understand lineage-based preservation.

§1. The Analogy

In an athletic relay race, the baton is not the point. The point is the unbroken continuity of the race itself — the handoff from one runner to the next, generation after generation, until the finish line.

The baton is merely the current physical carrier of that continuity.

Element	Analogue in preservation
The race	The lineage — the unbroken continuity of identity through time
The baton	The current physical instantiation (file, hard drive, ceramic media, stone tablet)
The runners	Successive generations of caretakers, archivists, or communities
The handoff	The lineage event — the documented act of transmission
The finish line	There is none. Preservation is infinite, or it fails.

§2. What the Baton Is Not

The baton is not the identity of the race.

- If the baton gets scratched, the race does not end.
- If the baton is dropped and picked up again, the race continues.
- If the baton is replaced mid-race with an identical baton, the race remains valid — provided the handoff is recorded and the lineage is clear.
- If the baton is lost and a new one is introduced without a documented handoff, the race ends. Not because the new baton is different, but because continuity was severed.

In lineage-primary terms: the object is the carrier. The lineage is the identity.

§3. What the Handoff Requires

A successful handoff requires four conditions — exactly the four predicates of 8PF:

Predicate	In relay terms
Origin (O)	The race has a declared starting point (tfo). Everyone agrees where and when it began.
Inheritance (I)	The baton is passed directly from runner to runner. No silent swaps. No gaps in custody.
Descent (D)	No runner disclaims the race. Each accepts the baton as the same race they received.
Sanctioned (S)	Each runner has legitimate authority to carry the baton. No one seizes it by force or fraud.

If any predicate fails, the lineage breaks. The race ends — even if the baton is still moving.

Example: A Practical Handoff

A digital photograph originally stored on magnetic tape is transferred to a hard disk as part of a preservation migration.

- The photograph’s existence on tape is documented as the declared starting point (Origin).
- The file is copied directly from tape to disk with no unrecorded substitutions (Inheritance).
- The receiving system records the file as the same photograph previously held (Descent).
- The transfer is performed and verified by an authorised custodian whose authority is recorded (Sanctioned).

This constitutes a valid lineage handoff. The physical carrier has changed — but the race continues.

§4. The Caring Gap

A relay race continues only as long as each generation chooses to pick up the baton and keep running.

No rulebook can force this. No technology can guarantee it. The finish line is not the point — but neither is running forever, if no one remembers why they are running.

The caring gap is the moment a generation looks at the baton and asks: “Why should I carry this?”

If they cannot answer, the race ends. The baton may sit in a vault, perfectly preserved, humming meaninglessly — exactly like The Humming Box.

§5. What This Means for Technical Preservation

Building better batons — more durable media, longer bit-retention, higher density — is good. But a better baton does not guarantee a better race.

A technical preservation strategy that focuses only on the baton is incomplete. It must also address:

- The lineage record — who declared inception? What transformations have occurred? Where is the provenance?
- The handoff mechanism — how is custody transferred between generations? How are lineage events recorded and verified?
- The caring gap — how does each generation renew its commitment to carrying the race forward?

These are not technical problems. They are governance, cultural, and ethical problems. Technology can support them — but it cannot replace them.

§6. One-Sentence Summary

The object is the baton, not the race. Build better batons — but never confuse them for the race itself.

§7. Caveat: The Race Can Restart

The analogy above describes a continuous race — one generation handing directly to the next. But this is not the only possible future.

A caveat is required.

If the race ends — if the last runner drops the baton and no one picks it up, if the caring gap swallows the lineage, if the archive is forgotten for centuries or millennia — the baton may still remain.

And if that baton carries enough information — not just data, but instructions — a future finder may recognise it for what it was.

The baton may say, in a language they can decipher:

“This was a race. Here is where it began. Here is how it was carried. Here is what it meant. If you wish, you may start running again.”

In this scenario, the original lineage is not resurrected. A dead lineage cannot be revived; the continuity of handoffs is irrecoverable.

But a new lineage can be founded — one that acknowledges its debt to the old.

The finder becomes a new tfo, declaring a new inception. The old baton becomes an ancestor, not a predecessor. The new race is not the same race — but it is inspired by it, informed by it, and grateful to it.

This is the deepest function of Deep Rosetta and the Technology Ladder: not to guarantee continuity, but to make restart possible.

A baton that carries only raw data — no origin story, no instructions, no Rosetta layer — is just a humming box. A baton that carries the story of the race offers something rarer: the possibility of beginning again.

§8. Revised One-Sentence Summary

The object is the baton, not the race. Build better batons — but also write on them what the race was for, so that if the race ends, someone may someday choose to begin again.